the chief minister,' was the advice I was given. I took the hint, choosing not to pursue it as it seemed like a private matter between two individuals.

But was it really a 'private' issue? Modi acknowledged Jasodhaben for the first time only while filing his nomination from the Vadodara seat for the 2014 elections. Till then, he had kept his marital status column blank because Election Commission rules do not make it mandatory to reveal it. But did it require a statutory change in election documents for Modi to publicly accept that he had a wife?

Yes, it may have been a forced marriage for the teenager who had left home soon after to join the RSS. Yes, it should not have any impact on his credentials as an able administrator. But should he not have at least acknowledged Jasodhaben's existence, or else annulled the marriage and given her 'freedom'? In an interview in the *Indian Express*, Jasodhaben hinted at her long years of loneliness as a schoolteacher who had never remarried, living in her brother's home. While Modi worked towards political glory, did he ever spare a thought for the girl he married when they were adolescents?

It's a question I would have ideally liked to ask Modi, but never did. Or dared to, even in private conversation. I don't think he would have answered it. Perhaps, like the chaiwallah story, the single-man image was designed to dress up his politics—the ideal *brahmachari* (bachelor) politician who had devoted his life to nation building was also part of the Modi myth-making factory. The 'bachelor' CM's appeal among Gujarati women voters was well known and his identity as the family-less *karmayogi* was subliminally projected in all advertising and political campaigns. Jasodhaben's identity was, tragically, almost expendable.

And yet, the shrillness of the attack on Modi by some of his critics was equally jarring. One of the worst offenders was the SP leader Azam Khan. In one rally, he said, 'Modi's hands are coloured with the blood of innocents'; in another, he spoke of how 'Kargil's peaks were conquered by Muslim, not Hindu, soldiers'. This was spiteful hate speech, designed to divide communities, the kind that deserved more than just an Election Commission ban.